Parshas Emor

Avodah, Tafkid, and the Path Back

Emor · Tahara · Zmanim · Pesach Sheni

I. A Word That Sets the Tone

Parshas Emor is a fascinating parsha to sit with. It opens with concepts of purity, of tahara, of marriage and relationships. It moves into the zmanim, the chagim, the structure of time. And it just continues to unfold. But if we take a step back before any of that, there is something quietly remarkable in the word the parsha is named for. Emor. It is not the most common word the Torah uses when introducing commandments. In most places, we find the lashon of dibur, a direct, authoritative speech. Here, the Torah chooses amirah, a softer register, a more deliberate and emotionally aware form of communication.

וַיֹּאמֶר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה, אֱמֹר אֶל הַכֹּהֲנִים בְּנֵי אַהֲרֹן, וְאָמַרְתָּ אֲלֵהֶם

"And Hashem said to Moshe: Speak to the Kohanim, the sons of Aharon, and say to them."

— Vayikra 21:1

Rashi picks up on the doubled expression immediately. Amar ve-amarta, the repetition, comes to obligate the adults to transmit the teaching to the children. The gedolim must teach the ketanim. This is not a side point. Before the Torah has stated a single law, it has already encoded the mechanism of transmission. Continuity is built into the opening breath of the parsha. And beyond that, the choice of amirah over dibur tells us something about what is about to be conveyed. Chazal understood amirah as carrying an earnestness alongside sensitivity. Some teachings require not only the right words but the right way of delivering them. What is about to be said is not easy. It requires a certain emotional awareness, a way of speaking that allows the message to actually land.

II. The Kohen and the Mirror

From the opening verse, the Torah moves directly into the specific obligations of the Kohanim. They must maintain tahara at all times. They are restricted in who they may marry. Their personal lives, how they live, who they build with, what they allow into their field, are not separate from their sacred function. Every dimension of who the Kohen is serves what the Kohen does.

It is easy, sitting here today without a Beis HaMikdash, to read these laws and feel like they belong to someone else. And in one sense, they do. Most of us are not Kohanim. But it is worth pausing before stepping back too quickly. The Kohen is called to be ready at every moment for the avodah. Not ready in theory, but concretely prepared. That means maintaining distance from tumah even when it is inconvenient, even when the pull of connection with someone who has passed is real and human and understandable. A Kohen Gadol cannot become tamei even for a parent. That is a striking restriction. And yet it is precisely that level of preparation that enables the Kohen Gadol to stand in the Kodesh HaKodashim on Yom Kippur and carry an entire nation before Hashem. The readiness is not separate from the encounter. It is what makes the encounter possible.

And if we take that principle and apply it outward, we arrive somewhere that does belong to all of us. Every Jew has a tafkid. Every Jew has a job. And the first tool for that job is the self. If the tool is not tended to, the work cannot be done properly.

III. What Tumah Really Costs

The specific tumah the Torah focuses on here is tumas meis, impurity that comes from contact with death. And it is worth asking why. What is it about death, about contact with the dead, that the Torah treats as so disruptive to the Kohen's capacity to serve?

When we think about death, we naturally think about limitation. About fragility. About the finite nature of life and all the things that did not get done. That line of thinking can take a person into sadness, into heaviness, into a kind of low-grade paralysis that makes avodah genuinely difficult. We all have our own experiences of loss. The reminder of mortality can be overwhelming in ways we do not always notice. Rebbe Nachman and many others return to this again and again: mitzvos need to be done with simcha. Avodah requires energy, presence, life. If a person is weighed down, disconnected, living in a space of heaviness, it becomes very difficult to do what they are meant to do. The Kohen's

distance from tumah is, on this level, a protection of the very conditions that allow him to serve.

But the Torah does not let this principle become an excuse for emotional avoidance. Even a Kohen Gadol, held to the highest standard of ritual purity, must become tamei if he encounters a meis mitzvah, a body with no one to attend to its burial. Human dignity, in that moment, overrides everything else. The Torah is not telling us to flee from difficulty or to build lives insulated from hard realities. It is telling us that there is a difference between chosen immersion in darkness and a purposeful response when the moment genuinely calls. We are not allowed to ignore what is in front of us. We are simply asked to be intentional about what we carry.

IV. Building a Mikdash Me'at

From the laws of tumah, the parsha moves into who the Kohen may and may not marry. And again, the instinct might be to read this as a narrow technical restriction that applies to a specific group. But the underlying principle speaks to something every person navigates. Who we build with determines the nature of what gets built. The Kohanim served in the Beis HaMikdash, but they went home at night. The home they returned to was either a support for that avodah or a pull against it.

Chazal teach that every Jewish home is a Mikdash me'at, a small sanctuary. The Shabbos table is a shulchan. The way we speak to each other, the space we create, the atmosphere we cultivate, these things are not decorative. They either make room for Shechinah or they crowd it out. And if that is true, then the question of who we are building with and how we are building together becomes one of the most important spiritual questions a person can ask. It is not a question of criticism. It is a question of clarity. Is the home we are creating one in which our tafkid can actually unfold?

V. Tamim: More Than Just Permitted

The parsha then turns to the korbanos, the offerings themselves. An animal brought to the mizbei'ach must be tamim, whole, without blemish. What is disqualified cannot be brought, regardless of intention. The integrity of the offering matters.

Sefer Tanya makes a distinction here that is worth sitting with. Something can be mutar, technically permitted, and still not be appropriate for where a person is in their avodah. The question of whether something is allowed is the beginning of the inquiry, not the end of it. The deeper question is whether what I am bringing into my life, into my time, into my consciousness, supports who I am trying to become. This is not about chumros. It is about coherence. The Kohen must be without blemish, and what he brings must be without blemish. The one who serves and what is offered need to match.

VI. Avodah Is Also About Time

After the korbanos, the parsha expands into the mo'adim. Shabbos, Pesach, Sefiras HaOmer, Shavuos, Rosh Hashanah, Yom Kippur, Sukkos. The calendar is laid out in full. And the message here is one that is easy to miss. Avodah is not only about the person and not only about what they do. It is also about when. The right person in the right place doing the right thing at the wrong time will still come up short.

The Torah gives us the capacity to be mekadesh time, to consecrate it, to recognize moments as charged with particular potential. We are living right now inside one of those charged windows. The Sefirah period stretches between the liberation of Pesach and the receiving of Torah at Shavuos. These are not just dates on the calendar. They are a structured season of preparation, and being present to that season, doing the inner work it invites, is itself a form of avodah. Avodah, the parsha keeps showing us, is the alignment of person, place, and time. All three need to come together. Most failures in avodah are not failures of will. They are failures of alignment.

VII. Pesach Sheni: The Question That Opens a Door

And then we come to today. Pesach Sheni. The concept of second chances.

If we go back to the beginning of the parsha, to the word emor and the idea that every Jew has a tafkid, a role, a job, then the natural follow-up question is: what happens when we miss it? What happens when the moment passes, when we were tamei, when we were not ready, when something got in the way? The answer is not in Emor itself. It comes from the portion of Bamidbar that gives us Pesach Sheni. A group of people had become tamei through involvement in a meis mitzvah. They had fulfilled an obligation. And because of

that, they found themselves unable to bring the Korban Pesach with the rest of Klal Yisrael. Facing that reality, they came before Moshe and asked:

לָמָּה נִגָּרַע

"Why should we be diminished?"
— Bamidbar 9:7

This question is everything. They did not reject the framework. They did not walk away. They did not decide that since they missed the moment, the moment no longer mattered. They came forward and said: we want back in. We are not willing to simply accept that our exclusion is permanent. Why should we lose out? From that question, Pesach Sheni was created. A date on the calendar, exactly one month later, born not from a prophecy but from the insistence of people who could not accept that missing a moment meant being shut out forever. The path back into avodah begins with that question, honestly asked. Not with guilt, not with self-erasure, but with a genuine refusal to accept permanent distance. When the question is real, the Torah shows us, an answer comes.

VIII. The Double Lashon and What We Pass Forward

We come back, at the close, to where we started. Amar ve-amarta. The double lashon. Rashi's insight that the obligation here is intergenerational. The adults must transmit to the children. And perhaps this is the deepest message of the parsha.

The avodah I do is mine, shaped by my moment and my circumstances and my specific challenges. I live in Eretz Yisrael. I navigate a world where learning and building and raising a family all happen alongside real pressures, real history, real threats. My tafkid looks different from my father's and will look different from my children's. And that is exactly as it should be. But the thread that connects those generations, the thing that gets passed forward, is not just information. It is how we lived, what we took seriously, what questions we asked, what we were willing to return to when we fell short. The double lashon is a reminder that avodah does not end with the person performing it. It ripples outward. Every genuine question asked at the threshold of return, every lamah nigraeh spoken with honesty, becomes part of an inheritance.

IX. What We Carry Into Shabbos

As we come into Shabbos, and carry with us the ongoing weeks of Sefirah moving toward Matan Torah, the parsha does not ask us for perfection. It asks for awareness. What does tahara look like for me right now, not in the Beis HaMikdash, but in my actual life? What am I allowing into my field of consciousness, what do I watch, what do I engage with, what pulls me into the kind of heaviness that makes avodah hard? Are the relationships I am building supporting the Mikdash me'at, or am I not even asking the question?

And if something has been missed, if there is a place where I feel disconnected, where the moment has passed and the distance has grown, the parsha meets me with Pesach Sheni. Not as a consolation prize, but as a genuine second door. The path back exists. It has always existed. But it begins where it always begins, with a real question. Lamah nigraeh. Why should I lose out? It does not require that everything be figured out. It only requires that the question be honest. And when it is, the Torah has already shown us that the door opens.

חזק ואחזק

Good Shabbos

Reflection Questions

> - *What does tahara look like in my actual life right now? What am I allowing in, and what have I been letting accumulate that makes avodah harder?*
> - *Is the home I am building a Mikdash me'at? Not in an idealized sense, but honestly: does the space I am creating make room for Shechinah?*
> - *Where in my life am I asking only whether something is permitted, rather than whether it is aligned with who I am trying to become?*
> - *Am I living with awareness of this moment in the Sefirah, or am I moving through it without using what it is actually offering?*
> - *Is there a place in my avodah where I have missed a moment and quietly accepted the distance? Am I willing to ask lamah nigraeh, and actually mean it?*
> - *What am I passing forward? Not just in what I teach, but in how I live. What does the next generation receive from watching me?*